

Australia has world-leading livestock traceability systems and an ongoing reform agenda ensuring these systems not only continue to meet but surpass future needs. This is key to preserving our biosecurity and enhancing export trade.

In [September 2022](#), (Commonwealth, State and Territory) Agriculture Ministers reaffirmed their commitment, first agreed in July 2022, for government to work collaboratively with industry to advance work on a national approach to Australia's livestock traceability systems. This includes Ministers' collective agreement to introduce a national mandatory individual electronic identification (eID) for sheep and goats.

To undertake this work the [National Biosecurity Committee](#) (NBC) established a new government-industry Sheep and Goat Traceability Task Force (SGTTF). Governments and industry are working together towards a mandatory national traceability system using eID for sheep and goats by 1 January 2025.

The SGTTF provides oversight of the national roll-out of eID for sheep and goats, advising senior officials and Agriculture Ministers on key implementation matters.

SGTTF membership includes:

- independent chairperson appointed by the NBC (Mr Ron Cullen)
- representatives from New South Wales, Tasmania, Victoria, Western Australia, South Australia and the Commonwealth governments (representing the other jurisdictions)
- a representative of SAFEMEAT
- representatives from peak councils for sheep, wool, goats, beef and/or dairy cattle industries
- representatives of retailers, processors and smallgoods.

Terms of Reference

[Sheep and Goat Traceability Task Force - Terms of Reference \(PDF 763 KB\)](#) [Sheep and Goat Traceability Task Force - Terms of Reference \(DOCX 402 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Communiqués

The SGTTF's formation meeting was on 16 September 2022. Key issues considered at Task Force meetings are in the communiqués listed below:

- [SGTTF communiqué 1 – October 2022](#)
- [SGTTF communiqué 2 - April 2023](#)
- [SGTTF communiqué 3 - October 2023](#)
- [SGTTF communiqué 4 - October 2024](#)

Sheep and goat eID National Implementation Plan

Implementing individual electronic identification (eID) for sheep and goats is a national effort. Information provided through the national Sheep and Goat Traceability Task Force will be shared to help coordinate the national effort. More information can be found on state and territory agriculture department websites.

National Principles – implementation of individual eID for sheep and goats

The SGTTF have developed National Principles - implementation of individual eID for sheep and goats to provide governments and industry with a framework to guide implementation nationally. They set out the minimum national requirements to guide planning and regulation and are intended to complement other business rule documents, i.e. [NLIS Sheep and Goat Standards](#) and individual state/territory regulation (legislation and policy documents).

Download

[National Principles – implementation of individual eID for sheep and goats \(PDF 156 KB\)](#) [National Principles – implementation of individual eID for sheep and goats \(DOCX 406 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Resources

SGTTF Resource and Support directory

A state-based directory that provides further information to support the rollout of eID for sheep and goats, including: agency contact information; and links to key information and industry resources, such as ordering and applying approved NLIS devices, moving sheep and goats with eID, using the NLIS database. The directory can also display the information based on livestock species, i.e. sheep or goats.

Please visit the [Resource and Support directory](#) webpage for more information.

The 5 whys on electronic identification eID tracing brochure

Discover key benefits to livestock traceability, biosecurity and export trade that will be achieved by moving from the current, mob-based approach to individual eID.

Download

If you have difficulty accessing the file, please contact livestock.traceability@aff.gov.au for assistance.

Woolly the sheep explainer video

A short video that has been created to highlight the benefits to livestock traceability in moving from the current, mob-based approach to individual eID.

WHERE'S WOOLLY

A story of mob-based movement vs eID tracing

Under the current national system, we track sheep and goats as mobs from property to property, using property identification codes, PIC's.

Let's look at how we currently track our sheep and goats under our mob-based movement system, meet Woolly.

Woolly the sheep lives on River Run Farm with 630 others.

Woolly's being moved to Wattle Downs Farm, along with 400 other sheep. Wattle Downs, Farm houses 1,300 sheep, including a few rams, which the owner bought from a breeder.

Sometime later, Wattle Downs decides to move a number of their sheep off the property.

60 sheep are sent to the abattoir, where 1,400 others have already been delivered.

75 sheep are sent to Shady Tree Farmstead, where there are already 575 head on property.

170 sheep are sent to a sale yard to be sold with 6,200 others. 500 sheep from that sale yard and moved to a feedlot housing 8,000 more sheep.

Finally, approximately 1,200 feedlot sheep are moved to an export depot where there are already 21,000 sheep.

But wait, where's Woolly?

Just through Woolly's potential journey, we've come into contact with about 40,280 sheep.

It's at this point we find out that the rams which were brought onto Wattle Downs Farm, where Woolly had been living, were carrying a disease.

Since we don't know where Woolly ended up or even if she is still at Wattle Downs, we have to trace all movements of all sheep off Wattle Downs Farm through all possible paths that the disease could have flowed through.

We also learned that the same breeder which sold the rams to Wattle Downs, sold to 26 other properties.

We now have to multiply all of these traces by 26.

That's 1,047,280 potentially exposed sheep and more than 130 pathways to follow.

But let's just look at finding Woolly in this instance.

If Woolly had been tagged with an eID tag with a unique electronic number, we would have been able to trace her and the others from Wattle Downs as individual sheep. Rather than needing to follow all the potential pathways they could have travelled down and all the other sheep they could have come into contact with.

Having individual eID allows us to find Woolly.

The time to contain a disease is reliant on the rate of traceability available. As a component of the whole system, eID helps us to trace specific stock, and know which others had contact with them, improving our rate of detection, containment and response.

Sheep and goat eID device selection explainer video

A short video that summarises the key information and processes for tag/device selection and moving livestock onto and off your property.

Webinars

The SGTTF webinar series is a joint initiative between the department, Sheep Producers Australia and the Goat Industry Council of Australia. Focus areas for the webinar have included:

- why traceability is important
- how eID for sheep and goats helps trace sheep more effectively than the mob-based system
- lessons learned from Victoria following its rollout of eID for sheep and goats.

2022 Industry-government co-design initiative

A co-design initiative was undertaken between August and November 2022, to help inform ongoing considerations on the national implementation of individual eID for sheep and goats. This included the feasibility of a 1 January 2025 implementation milestone agreed by Agriculture Ministers.

The co-design initiative provided a platform for stakeholders across the livestock production supply chain and governments to collaborate and combine their knowledge and views on the national livestock traceability system. The work built on the significant industry and jurisdictional progress already made to enhance livestock traceability over the past decade, including from the Victorian rollout of individual eID for sheep and goats and ongoing work by SAFEMEAT.

Key implementation areas were examined including:

- governance
- data
- infrastructure and technology
- cost implications
- communication and engagement

- timeframes
- long-term opportunities for broader livestock traceability system enhancements.

The co-design initiative delivered a number of outputs and communication materials to assist the national Sheep and Goat Traceability Taskforce in its considerations and advice to Agriculture Senior Officials and Ministers. Outputs included:

- technology and data requirements and dependency mapping
- material to support planning considerations for policy and regulatory changes
- communication materials and guidance for engagement across all supply chain participants
- a cost model that allows testing of different implementation approaches

Key findings and outputs

A summary pack was developed to share key findings and outputs. This comprises an overview, communication materials, the cost model and supporting assumptions guide.

Cost model and assumptions

The continued success and strength of our livestock traceability system overall is a shared responsibility. To understand the potential costs related to implementation of eID, a cost model tool was developed. The model was intended to support jurisdictions with their implementation decision making and planning. It was established at a specific point in time and is relevant in that context only.

The cost model does not produce a single definitive national figure for implementation costs.

The model allows for testing different implementation approaches based on 3 inbuilt scenarios and a range of assumptions and modifiable variables that facilitate this. The costs of implementing eID will be influenced by the final implementation approach taken by each jurisdiction, which could be a mixed approach of the 3 scenarios. The model does not consider the impact of any incentives or other support that may be provided to industry in helping meet the costs of transition.

The cost model guide and assumptions document must be read before using the model and when considering its outputs. For further information on interpretation of the model please contact livestock.traceability@aff.gov.au.

Download

[Livestock traceability cost model guide and assumptions \(PDF 1.5 MB\)](#) [Livestock Traceability - National Cost Model Tool \(XLSX 3.3 MB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/policy/partnerships/nbc/sheep-and-goat-traceability-task-force>